

Women's Specialists of Clear Lake

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Placenta Previa

A low-lying placenta can be managed safely with careful monitoring and a planned delivery

WHAT IS PLACENTA PREVIA?

- A condition where the **placenta lies low** in the uterus and covers all or part of the **cervix**
- The placenta provides oxygen and nutrients to your baby
- When it blocks the cervix, it can cause bleeding and make vaginal delivery unsafe
- Occurs in about **1 in 200 pregnancies** at delivery
- Many low placentas found early in pregnancy **move upward** as the uterus grows

RISK FACTORS

- **Prior cesarean delivery** or uterine surgery
- Previous placenta previa
- Multiple prior pregnancies
- **Smoking** during pregnancy
- Twin or multiple pregnancy
- Advanced maternal age
- Use of IVF or assisted reproduction

HOW IT IS DIAGNOSED

- Diagnosed by **ultrasound**, often during your routine anatomy scan
- **Transvaginal ultrasound** is safe and most accurate
- Follow-up ultrasound usually done at **32 weeks**, sometimes again at 36 weeks
- Most common symptom: **painless vaginal bleeding** in the 2nd or 3rd trimester
- Some women have no symptoms at all

MANAGEMENT & DELIVERY

- ✓ **If not bleeding:** avoid intercourse, nothing in the vagina, no heavy lifting
- ✓ **If bleeding:** hospital admission, IV fluids, fetal monitoring
- ✓ Planned **cesarean delivery at 36-37 weeks** if placenta still covers cervix
- ✓ Earlier delivery if bleeding is heavy or persistent
- ✓ Vaginal delivery may be possible if placenta is low but not covering cervix
- ✓ Delivery planned at hospital with **blood bank services**

POSSIBLE COMPLICATIONS

- Heavy bleeding before or during delivery
- **Preterm birth**
- Need for blood transfusion
- Cesarean delivery
- Increased risk of **placenta accreta** (placenta attaches too deeply), especially with prior C-sections
- Rarely, hysterectomy may be needed

WHAT YOU CAN DO

- ✓ Keep **all prenatal appointments** and follow-up ultrasounds
- ✓ **No sexual intercourse** and nothing inserted in the vagina
- ✓ Avoid strenuous activity and heavy lifting
- ✓ Stay close to a hospital and know your route
- ✓ **Do not allow a digital cervical exam** until previa is ruled out
- ✓ Discuss a delivery plan with your provider in advance

⚠ GO TO THE HOSPITAL IMMEDIATELY IF YOU EXPERIENCE

- ⚠ Any vaginal bleeding, even light spotting
- ⚠ Regular contractions
- ⚠ Abdominal or pelvic pain
- ⚠ Decreased baby movements
- ⚠ Leaking fluid from the vagina
- ⚠ Signs of labor
- ⚠ Lightheadedness or fainting
- ⚠ Rapid heartbeat or weakness

You Are Not Alone -- We Are Here to Guide You

Most women with placenta previa have healthy babies and deliver safely with planned cesarean. Many cases diagnosed early resolve on their own as pregnancy progresses. With close monitoring and a clear delivery plan, outcomes are excellent. Please call us any time you have questions or concerns -- we are here for you every step of the way.